Guest Speaker Summary: Opera Browsers

This week's guest speaker was Dan Berte, the Product Advocacy Director at Opera. Before he started at Opera, he ran the IoT vulnerability research program for Bitdefender. He worked on the Bitdefender BOX, a small device that protects every device on a home Local Area Network. He describes this device as the hero of the IoT world, and it was licensed by NETGEAR and large U.S. internet providers. He explained his research at DEF CON, HackSpaceCon, and Bloomberg

He started by covering the history of Opera and the web. Opera began as a research project at Telenor, Norway's phone company, in 1995 in Oslo, when the World Wide Web was about five years old. He started that Tim Berners-Lee built the first browser and server at CERN in 1990, and Hakon Wium Lie proposed the CSS infrastructure in 1994, that is still used today for webpage formatting. He joined Opera in 1999 as the CTO. He also stressed that Opera Mini was the first real mobile browser for phones back in 2004. Opera invented a long list of features that we take for granted today, including browser tabs, integrated search, built-in ad blocking, browser AI, dark mode, a news feed, video pop-out, mobile browsing, and much more.

Today, Opera is listed on the NASDAQ under the ticker OPRA. They have over 300 million users and has offices in Norway, Sweden, Poland, Germany, and France, plus more locations outside of Europe. He pointed out that Opera does not come preinstalled on any devices, so every user who uses Opera has intentionally downloaded it and chosen to use it as their primary browser. Opera currently has five browsers: Opera One as the everyday browser, Opera GX for gaming, Opera Neon with an agentic AI browser, Opera Mini, which compresses webpages for you, and Opera Air, which is a calmer browser with break reminders and breathing exercises. He also explained that their newest release, WebAI, allowed any webpage to call AI models straight from JavaScript with no APi key and no server, while staying private and fast.

The last part of the talk was his speaking about some projects that he is leveraging AI in order to build. In his free time, he is training his own AI model, hacking hardware, learning new trades, and building personal and business websites. One project of his was 101ADS.org, a website that uses his camera to spot billboards on Highway 101 as he drives up and down it. This app then reads the text, sorts it by category, and places it on the webpage on a map. Next, he built his own personal website, danberte.com, in about 20 minutes using Claude. Another was WASHYWASHY, a repurposed ESP32 chip that sends a notification to his phone when the washer has completed a cycle. His last and current project is a very small 'autonomous' Waymo, which is a Waymo I-PACE model on an RC drive car chassis. He uses an ESP32 board and sensors so it can drive 'autonomously'.